Everyone Needs More Meaning in Their Life

Marc Alexander · Week 8

1. Meaning and Structure *the meaning part*

- *Week 8:* Meaning and the World
- *Week 9:* Meaning and Words
- *Week 10:* Change in Meaning
- *Week 11:* Extending Meaning

2. Meaning and Grammar

- **Closed class words:** pronouns, conjunctions, auxiliary verbs, determiners, prepositions, etc
- **Open class words:** nouns, verbs, adverbs, and adjectives
- The closed classes often carry a **grammatical meaning** ('this is in the future', 'this is definite', 'these things are alternates', 'this is certain', 'this is on top of something else'); these are meanings which function to indicate relationships between open-class words
- The open classes often carry a **lexical meaning**…

3. Lexical Meaning

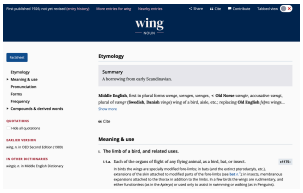


FIGURE 1 The OED Online entry for wing, noun, open at its etymology and first sense



FIGURE 2 The OED Online entry for punch, verb, showing its quotations

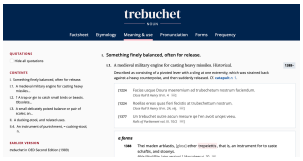


FIGURE 3 The OED Online entry for trebuchet, noun, a medieval siege engine

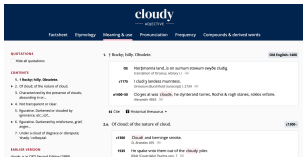


FIGURE 4 The OED Online entry for cloudy, adjective, with its Old English quotations

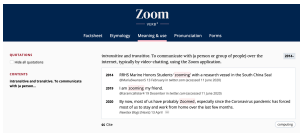


FIGURE 5 The OED Online entry for Zoom, verb, to communicate by video call, with quotations from 2014 to 2020

> Why study semantics? Semantics (as the study of meaning) is central to the study of communication; and as communication becomes more and more a crucial factor in social organization, the need to understand it becomes more and more pressing. Semantics is also at the centre of the study of the human mind – thought processes, cognition, conceptualization – all these are intricately bound up with the way in which we classify and convey our experience of the world through language.
>
> Leech 1981: ix

> If we ask where the meanings of words exist, the answer must be: in the minds of native speakers of the language.
>
> Saeed 2003: 6

4. How Do Words *Mean*?



FIGURE 6 A banana

- Words – like *banana* – have a relationship between the word as a thing made up of letters and sounds and the thing in the world it refers to.
- Debates about the relationship between words and things take into account:
  1. The *form* of the word (its sound or written image)
  2. The *referent* (the thing to which the word refers)
  3. The *concept* (the mental abstraction which the form articulates)

5. The Semiotic Triangle

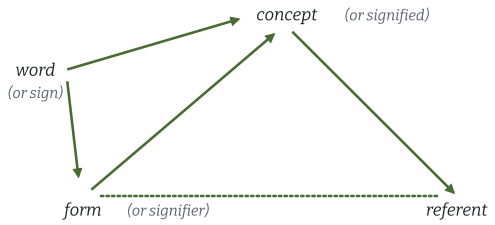


FIGURE 7 The semiotic triangle with the alternative terms: concept (or signified), form (or signifier), word (or sign)

6. Form and Referent

- The relationship between the *form* and the *referent* is a dashed line because there is (usually) **not a direct relationship** between the word's form and its referent



FIGURE 8 A pug sitting on a wooden floor with a paper label reading DOG on its head

- English: *dog*
- Dutch: *hond*
- Finnish: *koira*
- German: *Hund*
- Hawaiian: *ʻīlio*
- Icelandic: *hundur*
- Italian: *cane*



FIGURE 9 A black pug in a patterned harness, looking up at the camera

- Japanese: 犬
- Mandarin: 狗
- Korean: 개
- Arabic: *الكلب*
- Hebrew: *כֶּלֶב*
- Greek: *σκύλος*
- Russian: *собака*

7. *Usually* not a relationship

- Sometimes there *is* a relationship between the two:
  - **Onomatopoeia**, which means the mimicry of a concept by a word, such as *bang, splash, quack*, etc.



FIGURE 10 A comic by James Chapman, How to sound like a duck in 7 languages: quack, rap, mac, háp, coin, vak and praaks

- Sometimes there *is* a relationship between the two:
  - **Phonaesthesia**, which means when words expressing similar concepts share some characteristics of form
  - Many English words referring to a reflection of light from a surface begin with *gl-* (including *glint, glisten, gleam, glitter, glow*)
  - Many words to do with uncomfortable or twisting movement begin with *wr-* (including *writhing, wrenching, wresting, wringing, wreathing, wrying, writher, wriggle, wrinkle*)
  - Many words to do with wetness often begin with *sl-* (including *slurp, slake, slobber, slippery, slime, slop, slush, sludge, slide, sledge, slick, slither, slope, slalom*), etc.

8. How do you define a word?

- Because of the semiotic triangle, we know that we define words by combining a *concept* and a *form*.
- So when confronted with a form, we can refer to the concept by:
  - describing a set of characteristics of the concept, or
  - by pointing to a typical example (this is an *ostensive definition*)
- The concept part of a word does not lie itself in the examples, but through encountering examples we can come up with that concept. (And sometimes update it, as we'll see in week 10.)

9. Finding Examples

- When you give an ostensive definition, what example do you choose?
- Draw a *tree* so that you can use it as an ostensive definition.



FIGURE 11 Dragon's blood tree (*Dracaena cinnabari*)



FIGURE 12 Joshua tree (*Yucca brevifolia*)



FIGURE 13 A broad oak tree standing alone in a green field

- What about a *house*?



FIGURE 14 Wikimedia Commons

10. Prototypes

- How many of you actually live in a house like this?
  - Detached
  - Two stories
  - Smoke coming from a chimney
- How many of you would say things like "I'm going back to the house now" when you mean a flat?
- What is the definition of a *house*?

NOUN

I. **A building for habitation, and related senses.**

I.1.a. A building for human habitation, typically and historically one that is the ordinary place of residence of a family. (Cf. **home** *n.*[1] A.I.2.)

Sometimes (with capital initial) in the names of individual residences, esp. large mansions or country houses.

With *the*: a person's home.

FIGURE 15 The OED's first definition of house, noun: a building for human habitation, typically and historically one that is the ordinary place of residence of a family

- Shared typical features of a *set* create a *categorisation*
- We do this through our experience of the world as speakers
- But not all members are equally typical of the set
- Central, typical, members of a set are called prototypes
- We can usually get agreement from speakers of a particular variety as to the central members of a set

11. Vegetables

- Write down the first three typical vegetables you can think of
- When this experiment was done with US college students: *carrot, pea, corn, bean, potato, tomato, lettuce, spinach, asparagus, broccoli*

12. Prototypes

- Prototypes represent categories of sets
- Almost all sets are *fuzzy*
- Items on the edges of a fuzzy set can be arguable:
  - Centre of the set we call *birds*: sparrow, robin, blackbird, crow
  - Edge of the set: ostrich, penguin
  - Share some characteristics but definitely not: bats, aeroplanes
  - Have an argument over: dinosaurs

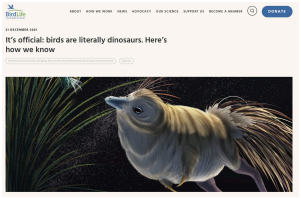


FIGURE 16 BirdLife International, 21 December 2021



FIGURE 17 A velociraptor drawn as a scaly reptile, in the style of older reconstructions



FIGURE 18 A velociraptor restored with feathers, in the style of current reconstructions

13. Follow-up

- This week, you should look under the *Meaning* heading in the online reading list (on Moodle) and sample a few introductory chapters from books on semantics.
- If you have questions, talk to your tutor or do please come see me (email me for a time!).